AI EXPLAINED SIMPLY

The AI Agent Loop: a copy-paste prompt

An AI agent is a model that runs a loop: **plan, act, check**, and repeats until the goal is done.

Anthropic defines agents as systems where LLMs "dynamically direct their own processes and tool usage", unlike workflows, which follow predefined code paths (source).

The idea of alternating reasoning and acting comes from the 2022 ReAct paper (arXiv 2210.03629).

The prompt (copy and paste)

```
You are an agent. Goal: [YOUR GOAL].
Work in a loop until the goal is done:
1. PLAN: list the next 1-3 steps.
2. ACT: do ONE step with a tool (search, run code, open a file).
3. CHECK: read the result. Did it work? If not, say why and fix the plan.
Stop when the goal is met, or after 8 loops, and tell me what you did.
```

Example goals

- Find three flights under a price you choose, and compare them in a table.
- Read a folder of notes and list the open questions.
- Run a script, read the error, fix it, run it again.

Tips

- Give it a clear goal and a stop rule (a maximum number of loops).
- Ask it to show the CHECK step: that is where mistakes get caught.
- Review what it did before relying on it.

Sources

- Anthropic, Building effective agents: https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/building-effective-agents
- Yao et al., ReAct (2022): https://arxiv.org/abs/2210.03629

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